

English I Use Every Day

In this lesson, we're focusing on everyday English that people actually use. You'll learn 19 common phrases that I, and many others, use all the time. These are the expressions that make daily conversations flow smoothly. By the end of this lesson, you'll be more comfortable using these phrases confidently in an English-speaking setting. I've also included a practice exercise at the end. Let's get started and make these everyday phrases part of your vocabulary bank.

Common everyday English phrases

While I like to imagine that I have a huge vocabulary and I use all kinds of interesting phrases every day, the truth is that **I repeat myself quite often from one day to the next.**

Like you, I spend most days doing similar activities: working, eating, hanging out with friends. And **I have a bank of phrases that I use every day without even thinking about them.** And that's what I want to give you in this lesson.

Learn these phrases and you'll be able to get through a lot of the day in an English-speaking environment without having to think too hard about what you're saying.

General Phrases

1. What a shame!

IPA Transcription: /wɒt ə ʃeɪm/

This is such a great **response to something negative or unfortunate** that happens or someone tells you about. It's better to use it for small inconveniences, like "Jean can't come tonight. She's busy. What a shame!" Don't use this when someone tells you their pet died or something more serious happened!



2. I haven't (got) a clue.

IPA Transcription: /aɪ 'hævnt (ɡɒt) ə kluː/

This phrase means **I really don't know**. I wouldn't recommend using this phrase with your boss or when something is very important! I use it with friends and family, for example -

- Do you know where the binoculars are?
- I haven't got a clue, sorry.

3. To cut a long story short...

IPA Transcription: /tə kʌt ə lɒŋ 'stɔːri ʃɔːt/

I really do need to work on making long stories shorter...

We use this phrase to say **I'm going to tell you the main point of the story**. We often say this when we realise we've been waffling on for a while and we need to get to the point. Sometimes, we preface this phrase with '**Anyway**', which is another word I use about 150 times a day.

Lucy's Note!

to waffle on - to talk about something for a long time

4. Make up your mind.

IPA Transcription: /meɪk ʌp jɔː maɪnd/

This is the last general one. It means **decide**! Or **make a decision**! We tend to use this phrase when we are a bit frustrated because someone can't or won't decide. I say it to my dog Diego when he's standing in the doorway, wondering whether to go outside or not, letting in lots of cold air!



Morning Phrases

I'm starting in the morning, but I only have three phrases to put here because... who talks a lot in the morning? However, if I'm saying anything at 7am, these are the ones that I'd use.

5. Mind if I grab the last...?

IPA Transcription: /maɪnd ɪf aɪ græb ðə lɑːst/

Mind if I grab the last... piece of toast/bagel/teabag? etc. This is a way **to ask if you can eat or use the last of something**. It's a question I ask my husband (and he asks me) several times a day. Notice how we omit 'Do you' from the beginning of the question - this ellipsis is common in informal questions.

6. I've got to dash.

IPA Transcription: /aɪv gɒt tə dæʃ/

This means I have **to leave quickly**. You can use it at any time of the day, but I say it most often in the mornings because that's usually when I am in a hurry.

7. Let's get a move on/get going.

IPA Transcription: /lets get ə muːv ɒn/get 'gəʊɪŋ/

And finally, this is a phrase that we often say when we really want to leave or we need to leave with someone else. It means, **"Come on! We need to go."** It's quite colloquial and it's not rude exactly, but it isn't the politest thing to say, so use it with friends and family, not with your boss.



Daytime Phrases

Let's move on to some things that I say every day during my work day.

8. Let's get cracking.

IPA Transcription: /lets get 'krækɪŋ/

I said this one at the beginning - it means **let's begin**. I love using this phrase because it's just more interesting than saying, "Let's start."

9. I've got back-to-back meetings today.

IPA Transcription: /aɪv ɡɒt ˌbæk tə 'bæk 'mi:tɪŋz tə'deɪ/

This really is my life at the moment. If I'm not filming a video, which is my favourite part of my job, I'm in a meeting. It means **I have one meeting after another with no breaks**. You could use it with any task you need to do one after another - back-to-back presentations/classes/filming (!)

10. I'm up to my ears...

IPA Transcription: /aɪm ʌp tə maɪ 'iəz/

This one is related to the previous phrase, and it means **I'm very busy**. We can simply say, "I'm up to my ears" or we could add "I'm up to my ears **in** work."



11. I'm going to power through.

IPA Transcription: /aɪm 'gəʊɪŋ tə 'paʊə θruː/

This is a phrase I say when **I'm going to work until I have finished**. We often say this when we're tired or if the task is particularly difficult. You can also say 'power on through'.

12. Give me (Gimme) a minute!

IPA Transcription: /ɡɪv miː ə 'mɪnɪt/

Classic. When someone needs me, **I often want to finish what I'm working on**. And when speaking quickly, '**Give me**' turns into '**Gimme**' /'ɡɪmi/.

13. I need to clear my head.

IPA Transcription: /aɪ niːd tə 'klɪə maɪ hed/

I use this phrase to say that **I need to take a break or do a different activity for a while**, usually because I'm feeling stressed or confused. If I've had back-to-back meetings or filming, I often need a bit of fresh air to clear my head.

14. I could do with a little pick-me-up!

IPA Transcription: /aɪ kʊd duː wɪð ə 'lɪtl ˌpɪk mi 'ʌp/

We use this phrase to say I need something, usually a drink or a snack, to boost my energy and/or my mood. **I often have a coffee or some biscuits as a pick-me-up in the afternoon**. In American English, people often say, **I could use a little pick-me-up!**



Evening Phrases

At last, the day is coming to an end. Here are some things that I say every evening.

15. I'm just wrapping up for the day.

IPA Transcription: /aɪm dʒʌst 'ræpɪŋ ʌp fə ðə deɪ/

This first one means **I am just finishing work or my tasks for the day.**

16. Next round's on me!

IPA Transcription: /'nekst 'raʊndz ɒn mi:/

What do Brits do when they finish work? Often, we go to the pub. This phrase means **I will buy the next set of drinks for our group.** I've talked a bit about rounds before in my videos, but it's very common in the UK, Ireland, Australia and some other English-speaking countries for people in a group to take turns buying drinks for everyone. Be careful before getting into a round of drinks with a big group of people - you might end up buying eight and drinking eight...

17. I'm a bit peckish.

IPA Transcription: /aɪm ə bɪt 'pekɪʃ/

And after the pub, we need to eat something. This phrase means **I'm hungry.** Not super hungry, but I could eat.



18. Fancy a nightcap?

IPA Transcription: /'fænsi ə 'naɪtkæp/

A little more about alcohol now. This question means **do you want one last drink before you go to bed?** It's usually alcohol, but it can actually refer to any drink. A hot cocoa could technically be a nightcap, though most English speakers will think you're offering them a whisky or a brandy or something like that.

19. I'm going to turn in.

IPA Transcription: /aɪm 'gəʊɪŋ tə ˌtɜːn 'ɪn/

And finally, this phrase means **I'm going to bed.** And that's how I end my day!

Bonus!

It slipped my mind /ɪt slipt maɪ maɪnd/ - a nicer, softer way to say **I forgot.** It means I really wanted and tried to remember, but it just disappeared from my mind. I say this all the time, all day, every day.

QUIZ!

Read each scenario. Choose which phrase matches each situation best. Write the correct letter on the line.

1. You are about to start a meeting, and you want to begin the discussion without any further delay.

Phrase: _____

2. You are late for an important meeting in the city, so you tell your husband/partner you need to leave immediately.

Phrase: _____

3. Your colleague looks at the last piece of pizza and seems hesitant, and then he says...

Phrase: _____

4. You are extremely busy at work, and your colleague asks how you're doing.

Phrase: _____

5. Your friend spills their drink. It's a minor incident, but it's still unfortunate.

Phrase: _____

6. You're at a restaurant, and your friend is taking a long time to choose what to order. You laugh and say...

Phrase: _____

7. Someone asks you about the location of an item you have no knowledge about.

Phrase: _____

8. You've had a long day filled with meetings. When a colleague asks about your schedule, you respond...

Phrase: _____

Phrase Bank

a. I'm up to my ears.	b. I've got to dash.	c. What a shame!	d. Mind if I grab the last slice?
e. I haven't got a clue.	f. I've had back-to-back meetings today.	g. Let's get cracking.	h. Make up your mind.

The End!

1) g 2) b 3) d 4) a 5) c 6) h 7) e 8) f

